

Gathered by love, glued by familial bonds

I had been a **footloose** solo traveller until health issues **bogged** me **down** and kept me **cloistered** in my home for nearly two years. In that period, I had nearly lost the **innate verve** to step out and see the world without being **accompanied** by the **spouse**. There was a certain **blitheness** to the spirit that came when I travelled alone and it was all taken away when an **ailment robbed** me **of** the confidence to **wing out** on my own.

Having come out of the phase for the most part, I had an opportunity to travel to India to attend a nephew's wedding earlier this month. However, I was caught between the **nervousness** of having to **set out** alone or giving the occasion a pass. The former meant **steeling up** to face whatever my mind and body would do to me during the time of travel. The former meant **giving up** a **glorious** opportunity to meet a **horde** of extended family members.

My dad came from a family of 13 siblings, most of whom have now moved on, leaving behind a **sprawling clan** of cousins who, over time, have built families of their own. Now with time, this family tree has grown **phenomenally**, with my cousins adding sons and daughters in-laws too. The **invitation** to the wedding **meant** having an **enviable** chance to meet many of them, and the list of people who had confirmed their attendance made me **slaver**. It was something I could not **gloss over**.

Good health or not, this was an occasion I did not want to miss because in a world that is getting **polarised** faster than a **sneeze**, one thing we need to **preserve** is the ties that **transcend differences** — the bonds of family that remind us, no matter how far we have **drifted**, there are roots that still hold us together.

The wedding promised to be more than just a celebration, it was a rare **convergence** of faces and stories I had not seen in years. A chance to relive old memories, **forge** new connections, and feel the warmth of belonging once again.

In the days leading up to my journey, I found myself replaying fragments of childhood spent with these cousins — the carefree gatherings on family occasions, the **teasing banter** that stitched us together, and the quiet comfort of knowing we belonged to the same **expansive** family tree. Life had since **scattered** us across continents, and while social media kept us loosely **tethered**, it was not the same as being in each other's presence — seeing familiar eyes **light up**, hearing voices unchanged by time, and **embracing** those whose touch still carried the warmth of home.

I knew this gathering would be more than just a reunion, it would be a gentle reminder that no matter how far we **wander**, we remain connected by unseen threads **woven** from shared memories, loud laughter, and the silent understanding that we are part of something bigger than ourselves. And so, with a heart both **anxious** and **eager**, I packed my bags, not just for a wedding, but for a journey back to the roots that still held me **fast**.

And boy, was I **overwhelmed**! From the first hug I received from my **paternal** aunt when I **walked into** her room through the number of **embraces** I got from dozens of people I was meeting after a long time, it was two days of nonstop reminders about how deeply **intertwined** our lives were, despite the years and distances that had come between us. Each embrace seemed to unlock a memory. Conversations flowed like an unbroken river, as if it had never stopped, carrying with them the **warmth** of familiarity and the quiet **reassurance** that some connections never truly **fade**.

In those two days, I found myself moving through a reel of faces and voices, yet each **encounter** felt personal and **profound** as if no time had **lapsed** at all. It was not just a family gathering, it was a homecoming for the heart, a reminder that **love**, in its purest form, **doesn't** need constant **tending to thrive**. It waits patiently, ready to embrace us the moment we return.

All we need to **nurture** is a willingness to **cruise** into embraces and a bonding that are not **encumbered** by status, health conditions, time lapse, achievements or other **highs and lows** of a world that has no time to stand and share.

For this reason alone, I have resolved to attend any major celebration in the family if conditions are **conducive**, not just to enhance my experience of life, but also to let the bonds that time **threatens** to **fray** find their strength again, because some ties deserve to be nurtured, not **merely** remembered.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Footloose** (adjective) – Free-spirited, Unrestrained, Unattached, Independent, Carefree आज़ाद
2. **Bog down** (phrasal verb) – Stuck, Overwhelm, Burden, Hinder, Slow फँस जाना
3. **Cloister** (verb) – Isolate, Confine, Seclude, Shelter, Withdraw एकांत में रखना
4. **Innate** (adjective) – Inborn, Natural, Intrinsic, Inherent, Instinctive सहज
5. **Verve** (noun) – Energy, Enthusiasm, Vigor, Passion, Spirit जोश
6. **Accompany** (verb) – Escort, Attend, Follow, Join, Go with साथ जाना
7. **Spouse** (noun) – Partner, Husband, Wife, Mate, Consort जीवनसाथी
8. **Blitheness** (noun) – Cheerfulness, Lightheartedness, Joy, Carefreeness, Gaiety हल्कापन
9. **Ailment** (noun) – Illness, Disease, Disorder, Condition, Affliction बीमारी
10. **Rob** (of) (verb) – Deprive, Strip, Dispossess, Divest, Take away छीन लेना
11. **Wing out** (phrasal verb) – Fly, Travel, Depart, Venture, Set out उड़ान भरना
12. **Nervousness** (noun) – Anxiety, Tension, Unease, Apprehension, Worry घबराहट
13. **Set out** (phrasal verb) – Begin, Start, Embark, Depart, Commence शुरू करना
14. **Steel up** (phrasal verb) – Brace, Prepare, Strengthen, Fortify, Gird खुद को मजबूत करना
15. **Give up** (phrasal verb) – Abandon, Quit, Surrender, Relinquish, Renounce छोड़ देना
16. **Glorious** (adjective) – Magnificent, Splendid, Majestic, Wonderful, Brilliant शानदार
17. **Horde** (noun) – Crowd, Throng, Multitude, Swarm, Mass भीड़
18. **Sprawling** (adjective) – Extensive, Vast, Widespread, Expansive, Far-reaching फैला हुआ
19. **Clan** (noun) – Family, Tribe, Kin, Group, Community कुल
20. **Phenomenally** (adverb) – Exceptionally, Remarkably, Extraordinarily, Incredibly, Astonishingly अद्भुत रूप से
21. **Envable** (adjective) – Desirable, Coveted, Admirable, Attractive, Prized ईर्ष्यापूर्ण
22. **Slaver** (noun) – Drool, Salivate, Dribble, Covet, Desire लार टपकाना

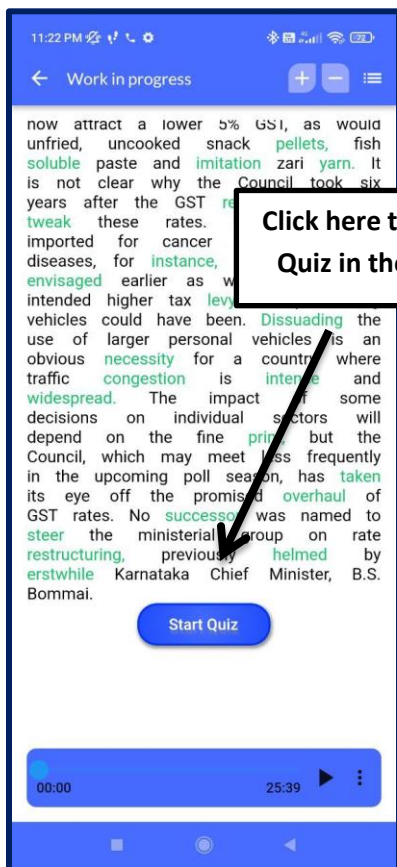
23. **Gloss over** (phrasal verb) – Ignore, Overlook, Disregard, Downplay, Neglect नज़रअंदाज़ करना
24. **Polarise** (verb) – Divide, Split, Separate, Fragment, Alienate ध्रुवीकरण करना
25. **Sneeze** (noun) – Sternutation, Sniffle, Cough, Sneeze reflex छींक
26. **Preserve** (verb) – Protect, Conserve, Maintain, Safeguard, Sustain संरक्षित करना
27. **Transcend** (verb) – Surpass, Exceed, Overcome, Rise above, Go beyond पार करना
28. **Differences** (noun) – Argument, dispute, disagreement, quarrel मतभेद
29. **Drift** (verb) – Wander, Float, Meander, Roam, Stray बहना
30. **Convergence** (noun) – Meeting, Intersection, Union, Gathering, Merging मिलन
31. **Forge** (verb) – Create, Build, Develop, Establish, Shape बनाना
32. **Teasing** (adjective) – Mocking, Playful, Joking, Taunting, Bantering छेड़खानी
33. **Banter** (noun) – Joking, Repartee, Wit, Chitchat, Ribbing मज़ाक
34. **Expansive** (adjective) – Extensive, Broad, Wide, Spacious, Vast विस्तृत
35. **Scatter** (verb) – Disperse, Spread, Strew, Distribute, Dissipate बिखेरना
36. **Tether** (verb) – Tie, Bind, Secure, Fasten, Anchor बांधना
37. **Light up** (phrasal verb) – Brighten, Illuminate, Glow, Shine, Sparkle रोशन करना
38. **Embrace** (verb) – Hug, Hold, Clasp, Enfold, Cuddle गले लगाना
39. **Wander** (verb) – Roam, Drift, Stray, Meander, Ramble भटकना
40. **Weave** (verb) – Intertwine, Braid, Knit, Entwine, Plait बुनना
41. **Anxious** (adjective) – Nervous, Worried, Apprehensive, Tense, Uneasy चिंतित
42. **Eager** (adjective) – Keen, Enthusiastic, Excited, Impatient, Avid उत्सुक
43. **Fast** (adjective) – Firm, Secure, Fixed, Tight, Steady मजबूत
44. **Overwhelm** (verb) – Overpower, Overcome, Flood, Swamp, Engulf अभिभूत करना
45. **Paternal** (adjective) – Fatherly, Protective, Supportive, Caring, Parental पैतृक
46. **Walk into** (phrasal verb) – Enter, Step into, Arrive, Come into, Access अंदर जाना

47. **Embrace** (noun) – Hug, Cuddle, Hold, Clasp, Enfold गले लगाना
48. **Intertwine** (verb) – Entwine, Interlace, Interweave, Connect, Link गूँथना
49. **Warmth** (noun) – Affection, Kindness, Friendliness, Cordiality, Heat गर्मजोशी
50. **Reassurance** (noun) – Comfort, Encouragement, Support, Confidence, Solace आश्वासन
51. **Fade** (verb) – Dim, Disappear, Vanish, Wane, Dull फीका पड़ना
52. **Encounter** (verb) – Meet, Face, Confront, Experience, Come across सामना करना
53. **Profound** (adjective) – Deep, Intense, Significant, Thoughtful, Serious गहरा
54. **Lapse** (verb) – Expire, End, Cease, Terminate, Pass समाप्त होना
55. **Tend** (to) (verb) – Care for, Look after, Nurture, Manage, Attend ध्यान देना
56. **Thrive** (verb) – Flourish, Prosper, Succeed, Grow, Bloom फलना-फूलना
57. **Nurture** (verb) – Foster, Cultivate, Encourage, Support, Develop पोषण करना
58. **Cruise** (verb) – Sail, Glide, Drift, Travel, Journey यात्रा करना
59. **Encumber** (verb) – Burden, Weigh down, Hamper, Hinder, Restrict बोझ डालना
60. **Highs and lows** (phrase) – Ups and downs, Peaks and valleys, Successes and failures, Good and bad times उतार-चढ़ाव

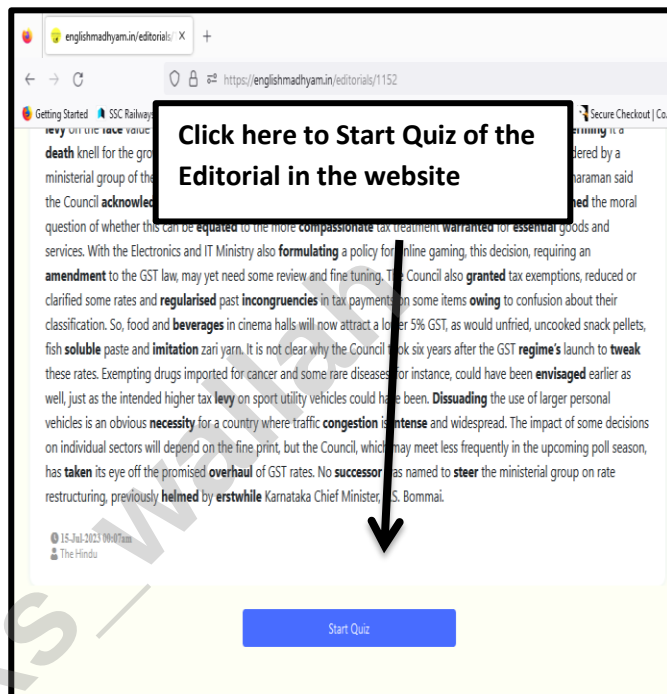
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Transition from Solo Travel to Confinement:** The author, once a passionate solo traveler, was confined to their home for nearly two years due to health issues, losing the confidence to travel alone.
2. **Loss of Innate Spirit:** The ailment robbed the author of the blitheness and independence they once felt while traveling solo.
3. **Opportunity to Travel Again:** The author had a chance to attend a nephew's wedding in India, but was torn between nervousness about traveling alone and the desire to reconnect with family.
4. **Extended Family Ties:** The author comes from a large family, with 13 paternal siblings and a sprawling clan of cousins, now expanded with in-laws and new generations.
5. **Importance of Family Bonds:** The wedding offered a rare opportunity to reunite with extended family, reminding the author of the importance of preserving familial ties in a polarized world.
6. **Emotional Dilemma:** The author struggled with the decision to travel, weighing the physical and emotional challenges against the joy of reconnecting with loved ones.
7. **Childhood Memories:** The author reminisced about childhood gatherings with cousins, the teasing banter, and the sense of belonging that came from being part of a large family.
8. **Scattered Lives:** Over time, family members had dispersed across continents, with social media serving as a weak substitute for in-person connections.
9. **Reunion as a Homecoming:** The wedding was more than a celebration; it was a chance to relive memories, forge new connections, and feel the warmth of belonging.
10. **Overwhelming Emotions:** The author was deeply moved by the hugs, embraces, and conversations with family members, feeling a profound sense of connection despite years of separation.
11. **Timeless Connections:** The reunion felt as if no time had passed, with conversations flowing effortlessly and memories resurfacing with each embrace.
12. **Family as a Source of Strength:** The gathering served as a reminder that familial bonds remain strong, even when life pulls people apart.
13. **Love Beyond Time and Distance:** The author realized that love and connection do not require constant tending; they endure and thrive when nurtured.
14. **Resolution to Prioritize Family:** The author resolved to attend future family celebrations, recognizing the importance of strengthening bonds that time and distance threaten to weaken.
15. **Life-Enriching Experience:** The reunion was not just a family gathering but a homecoming for the heart, reinforcing the value of love, connection, and shared roots.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



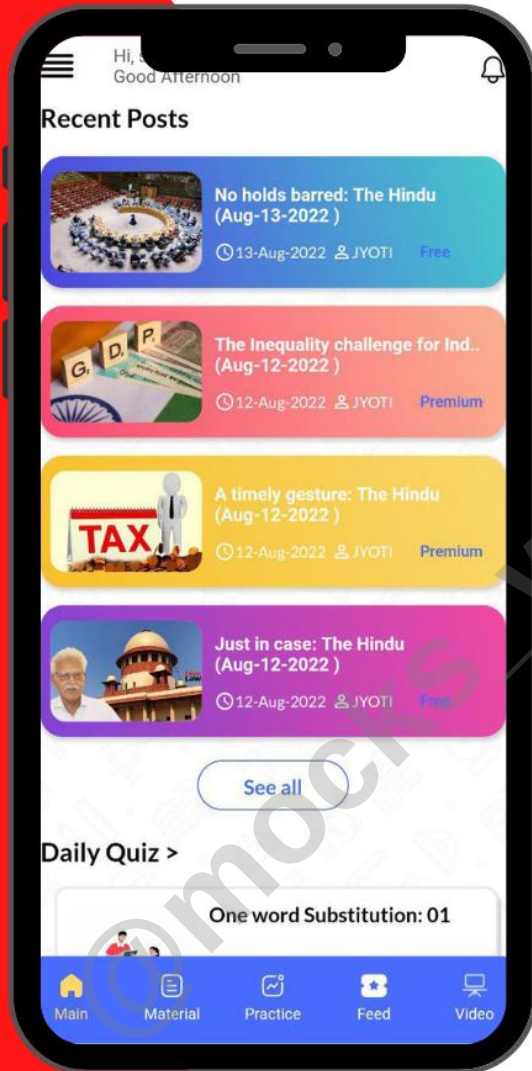
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